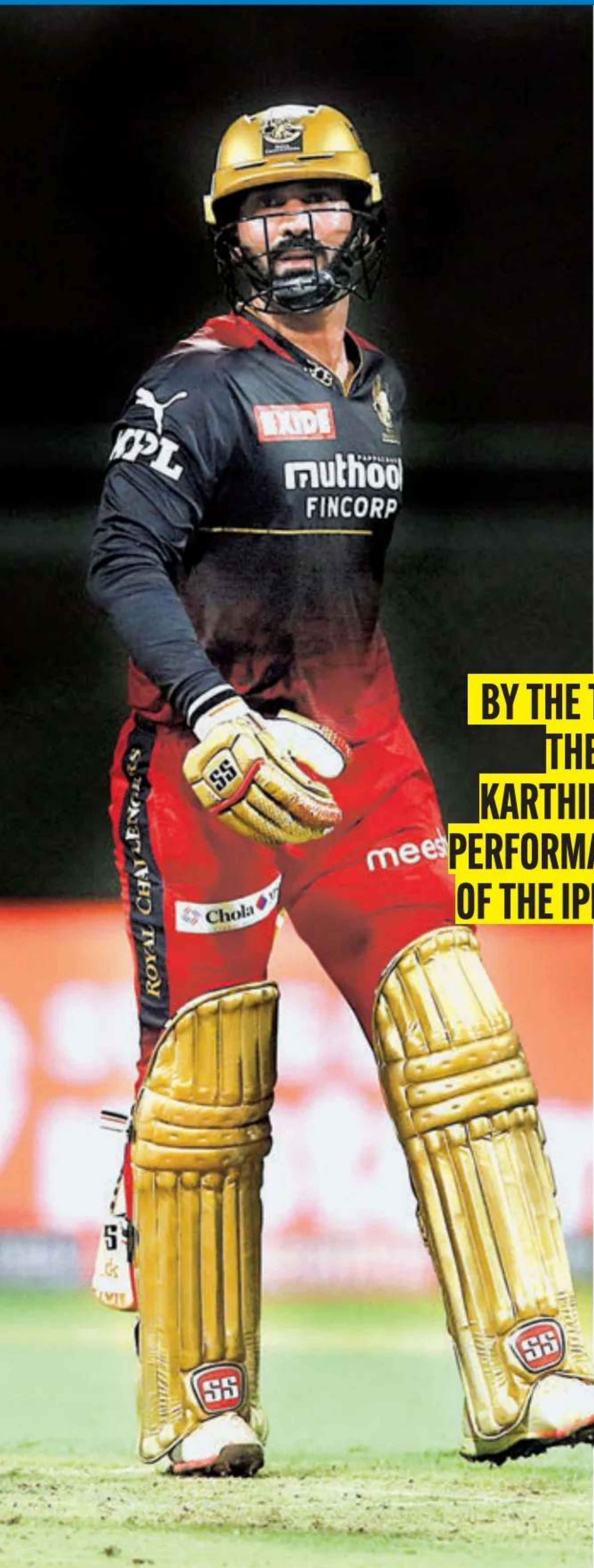




Strong contender: Rishabh Pant, who has come back from a life-threatening accident, is the frontrunner for the wicketkeeper's slot. SPORTZPICS/IPL

Karthik has so far amassed 251 runs, with a couple of fifties. And his record of guiding India home in tricky situations — a la the Nidahas Trophy back in 2018 — certainly adds gloss to his glorious resume.

However, the four-member selection committee, led by Ajit Agarkar, will find it challenging. **Focusing on breaking India's title jinx in an ICC tournament since 2013, the selectors, like the team management, will have to answer a fundamental question before they sit down to pick the final 15—should the side be constructed based on the current trend or should it go by reputation and opt for big names?**

According to former national selector Bhupinder Singh, the factor that will play a significant role is the playing conditions. "We are playing in New York, and there is little idea about the pitches. The boundary's size and the playing surface's character will count a lot. As for the team, I think it is more or less settled — six batters, two all-rounders, three fast bowlers, and two spinners,"

BY THE TIME THE T20 WORLD CUP BEGINS IN THE USA AND THE WEST INDIES, DINESH KARTHIK WILL BE 39. HOWEVER, HIS SUPERB PERFORMANCE AS A FINISHER IN THIS EDITION OF THE IPL MAKES HIM A STRONG CONTENDER

said Bhupinder.

Selection is always a tricky start, but going by tradition, it is unlikely that the selection committee would allow room for experiments. It would like to proceed with the players who have been part of the set-up over the years. However, the only position that could see three-way battle is the wicketkeeper's. Going by the current form, Karthik has tough competition from Samson and the comeback man Pant.

However, former India wicketkeeper-batter and national selector Syed Saba Karim puts his money on Pant. "You need to pick players who have done it for you," Karim says. "The way Rishabh has come back, he has carved his script here, and he is an absolute match-winner and can play those impact innings."

Pant has had a fairy-tale-like comeback to professional cricket 15 months after a horrific car crash. As the captain of Delhi Capitals, Pant has been exceptional both with the bat and behind the stumps. Karim is impressed with the youngster and has no